

DU's new tie-breaker for undergraduate admissions: Tripping on reform

When Delhi University (DU) adopted the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) for undergraduate admissions in 2022, it was seen as a long **overdue** step toward **standardisation** of a **sprawling ecosystem**. An **improvement** over the Central Universities Common Entrance Test **introduced** in 2010 for a **handful** of central universities, CUET promised to **level the playing field** by replacing the **uneven** Class XII cut-off system with a single, **uniform** test. It was an opportunity to move beyond the **disparities** of state boards, **streamline** admissions, and focus **solely** on **merit**. Though **premised on fairness**, **some** of the changes to the admission process this year — especially the addition of Class X scores as the **penultimate** tie-breaker, **supplanting** alphabetical order of candidates — **tread a delicate line**. In a country where access to higher education remains **intensely** competitive and deeply **consequential**, they risk reintroducing **anxieties** that CUET was designed to eliminate.

With 71,624 seats across 79 undergraduate programmes in 69 colleges up for applications this academic year, the new tie-breaker has been designed to offer, as DU's **dean** of admissions has put it, a "more **rational** and merit-based approach" to break CUET **deadlocks**. Class X performance is a **reliable** indicator of **consistency**, **arguably** less **vulnerable** to coaching-driven **score inflation**. It also reduces the **arbitrariness** of alphabetical tie-breakers, which, though **neutral**, fail to reward academic effort. However, it risks **undermining** CUET's foundational principle, **rooted** in the spirit of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, which **advocates** for equity and **inclusivity** in higher education. In **decoupling** undergraduate admission from board **variability**, CUET sought to ensure that scores alone did not **dictate** a student's future. **Reintroducing** board scores from Class X **opens up** old **vulnerabilities**. State board **curricula** and grading systems continue to **vary** widely in difficulty and **leniency**. As a result, **students** from better-resourced boards or urban backgrounds **may** gain an unintended advantage. Moreover, NEP 2020 encourages **holistic assessments** over **rigid reliance on** any single score. **Shifting** the focus to grades — especially one from years prior — **might** be **counterproductive** for students who have **matured** academically in the years since or had faced personal **setbacks** at that stage.

Instead of **tying** the admission process up with three separate academic records — CUET, Class XII, and Class X — a possible alternative could have been the option of more **granular** tie-breakers within CUET itself; its scores could have been extended to more **decimal** places or to domain-specific section scores. As India reimagines its higher education **architecture**, **policymakers** must be careful that **efforts** to fix procedural gaps **do** not **reignite** old **apprehensions** or come at the cost of inclusivity. **[Practice exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Trip** (on) (verb) – stumble, falter, slip, blunder, misstep ठोकर खाना
2. **Overdue** (adjective) – late, delayed, pending, belated, behind schedule देर से हुआ
3. **Standardisation** (noun) – normalization, unification, regulation, systematization, uniformity मानकीकरण
4. **Sprawling** (adjective) – expansive, spreading, extensive, widespread, rambling फैला हुआ
5. **Ecosystem** (noun) – environment, framework, system, structure, network पारिस्थितिकी तंत्र
6. **A handful of** (phrase) – a few, some, limited number, small group, select few कुछ ही
7. **Level the playing field** (phrase) – equalize, balance, standardize, neutralize, harmonize समान अवसर देना
8. **Uneven** (adjective) – irregular, inconsistent, unequal, lopsided, patchy असमान
9. **Uniform** (adjective) – consistent, standardized, identical, equal, unchanging एक समान
10. **Disparity** (noun) – difference, inequality, imbalance, divergence, gap असमानता
11. **Streamline** (verb) – simplify, rationalize, optimize, systematize, organize सुव्यवस्थित करना
12. **Solely** (adverb) – only, exclusively, merely, entirely, purely केवल
13. **Merit** (noun) – ability, excellence, worthiness, talent, qualification योग्यता
14. **Premise** (on) (verb) – base, assume, found, establish, postulate आधार बनाना
15. **Fairness** (noun) – justice, impartiality, equity, objectivity, balance निष्पक्षता
16. **Penultimate** (adjective) – second-last, next to last, preceding final, near-end, final-but-one अंतिम से पहले
17. **Supplant** (verb) – replace, displace, override, substitute, oust प्रतिस्थापित करना
18. **Tread a line** (phrase) – maintain balance, walk cautiously, navigate carefully, stay moderate, avoid extremes संतुलन बनाए रखना
19. **Delicate** (adjective) – sensitive, fragile, tricky, subtle, fine नाजुक
20. **Intensely** (adverb) – strongly, deeply, extremely, vigorously, fiercely तीव्रता से
21. **Consequential** (adjective) – important, significant, impactful, serious, far-reaching महत्वपूर्ण

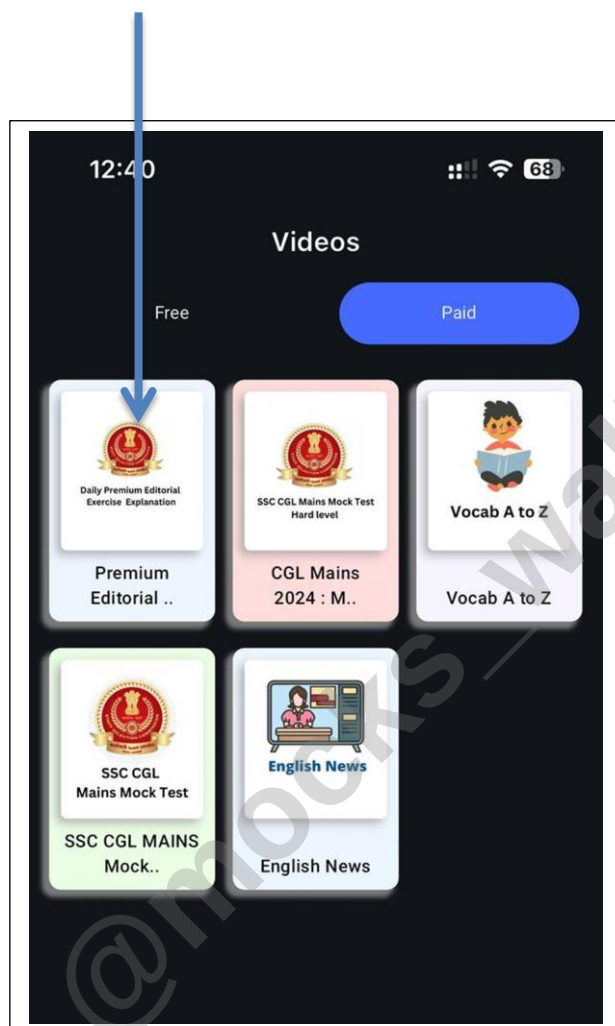
22. **Anxiety** (noun) – worry, nervousness, fear, unease, apprehension चिंता
23. **Dean** (noun) – academic head, administrator, head, principal, director विभागाध्यक्ष
24. **Rational** (adjective) – logical, reasonable, sensible, coherent, sound तर्कसंगत
25. **Deadlock** (noun) – stalemate, impasse, standstill, gridlock, standoff गतिरोध
26. **Reliable** (adjective) – dependable, trustworthy, credible, consistent, faithful भरोसेमंद
27. **Consistency** (noun) – uniformity, stability, coherence, regularity, reliability एकरूपता
28. **Arguably** (adverb) – possibly, potentially, conceivably, plausibly, debatably तर्कपूर्वक
29. **Vulnerable** (to) (adjective) – exposed, prone, susceptible, at risk, defenseless असुरक्षित
30. **Score inflation** (noun) – the tendency of educators to award higher grades than students actually deserve, leading to an overall increase in average grades over time without a corresponding increase in student performance
31. **Arbitrariness** (noun) – randomness, inconsistency, whim, unpredictability, capriciousness मनमानी
32. **Neutral** (adjective) – unbiased, impartial, objective, detached, fair निष्पक्ष
33. **Undermine** (verb) – weaken, sabotage, erode, impair, subvert कमजोर करना
34. **Root** (in) (verb) – base, anchor, found, originate, ground आधारित होना
35. **Advocate** (verb) – support, recommend, promote, endorse, champion समर्थन करना
36. **Variability** (noun) – fluctuation, inconsistency, divergence, deviation, instability परिवर्तनशीलता
37. **Dictate** (verb) – determine, command, prescribe, impose, direct तय करना
38. **Vulnerability** (noun) – weakness, susceptibility, exposure, sensitivity, risk कमजोरी
39. **Curricula** (noun) – syllabi, course content, study plans, academic programs, educational outlines पाठ्यक्रम
40. **Vary** (verb) – differ, change, fluctuate, alter, shift भिन्न होना
41. **Leniency** (noun) – mercy, compassion, indulgence, tolerance, permissiveness नरमी
42. **Holistic** (adjective) – comprehensive, all-encompassing, integrated, overall, inclusive समग्र

43. **Assessment** (noun) – evaluation, appraisal, analysis, review, judgment मूल्यांकन
44. **Rigid** (adjective) – strict, inflexible, firm, unyielding, unbending कठोर
45. **Reliance** (on) (noun) – dependence, trust, faith, confidence, assumption निर्भरता
46. **Counterproductive** (adjective) – harmful, detrimental, ineffective, adverse, unhelpful विपरीत प्रभाव डालने वाला
47. **Mature** (verb) – grow, develop, evolve, progress, ripen परिपक्व होना
48. **Setback** (noun) – obstacle, hindrance, difficulty, reversal, defeat झटका
49. **Tie** (verb) – link, bind, connect, associate, attach बाँधना / जोड़ना
50. **Granular** (adjective) – detailed, specific, fine, precise, thorough सूक्ष्म
51. **Decimal** (adjective) – fractional, numeric, point-based, base-ten, precise दशमलव
52. **Architecture** (noun) – structure, framework, design, system, organization संरचना
53. **Policymaker** (noun) – lawmaker, legislator, planner, decision-maker, administrator नीति निर्माता
54. **Reignite** (verb) – restart, revive, resume, rekindle, reawaken फिर से शुरू करना
55. **Apprehension** (noun) – fear, anxiety, worry, concern, unease भय / चिंता

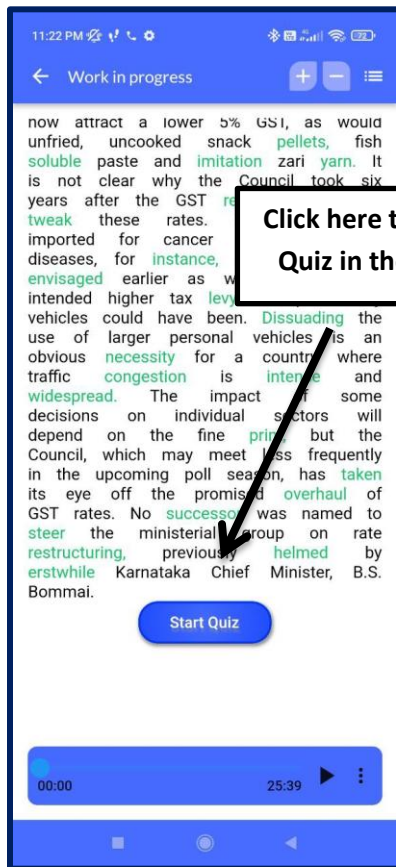
Summary of the Editorial

1. **CUET Adoption:** Delhi University adopted the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) in 2022 to standardize undergraduate admissions.
2. **CUET's Goal:** The test aimed to replace the uneven Class XII cut-off system with a uniform exam, leveling the playing field.
3. **Improvement Over CUCET:** CUET expanded on the Central Universities Common Entrance Test (CUCET) of 2010 by covering many more universities.
4. **Standardisation Need:** CUET sought to overcome disparities in state board exams and streamline admissions based solely on merit.
5. **New Tie-Breaker Introduced:** This year, DU added Class X scores as the penultimate tie-breaker, replacing the previous alphabetical order method.
6. **Rationale:** DU's dean of admissions described it as a "more rational and merit-based approach" to resolve ties among CUET applicants.
7. **Class X Scores' Strength:** Class X performance is seen as a consistent indicator, less prone to inflated scores from intensive coaching.
8. **Drawback of Alphabetical Method:** Though neutral, using candidate names for tie-breakers failed to reflect academic effort.
9. **Equity Concerns:** Reintroducing board scores risks undermining CUET's aim of equitable access by reintroducing disparities from variable board standards.
10. **Board Variability:** State board grading systems differ widely, giving unintended advantages to students from lenient or resource-rich boards.
11. **Inclusivity Risk:** The change could disadvantage students from less privileged backgrounds, conflicting with NEP 2020's equity focus.
12. **Holistic Assessment:** NEP 2020 promotes holistic evaluations over rigid reliance on single or outdated scores.
13. **Outdated Performance:** Class X scores may not reflect a student's current abilities, especially for those who improved academically later.
14. **Alternative Solutions:** The editorial suggests refining CUET tie-breakers using more precise decimal scores or domain-specific sections instead of old board marks.
15. **Policy Caution:** Policymakers must ensure reforms avoid reigniting old anxieties and compromising inclusivity in higher education admissions.

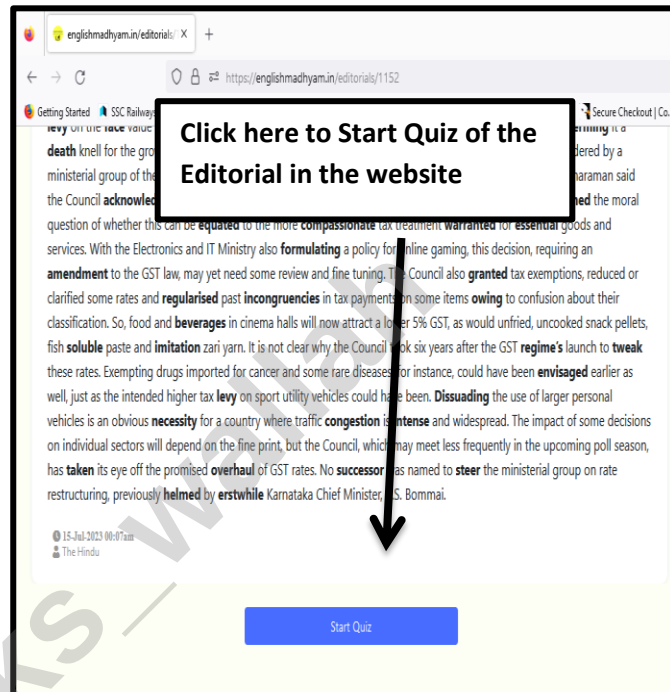
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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